

PARICHAY

From Google Form to Instagram Grid — Automatically

A complete, low-code build framework for a junior-introduction directory website that collects data + photos, auto-generates your Canva grid posts, and doubles as a searchable college info hub.

Built for: a college society/committee team with little to no coding background, using AI "vibe-coding" tools (Lovable, v0, Bolt, Antigravity, Gemini) instead of writing code by hand.

Contents

1. The Big Picture — How the whole system fits together
2. Step 1: The Google Form (your data intake)
3. Step 2: The Database — where the data actually lives
4. Step 3: Auto-generating the Canva grid posts
5. Step 4: The Website — directory, search, extra pages
6. Step 5: Posting automation — what's realistic
7. Recommended Tool Stack (mapped to tools you already have)
8. Build Roadmap — phase by phase
9. Team Roles
10. Extra Feature Ideas
11. Risks, Consent & Data-Handling Notes
12. Cost Summary

1. The Big Picture

Think of the whole project as a pipeline with four stations. Data enters at one end (the Google Form) and two finished products come out the other end: an Instagram-ready grid image set, and a live, searchable website page for that student.

The pipeline

Stage	What happens	Who/what does it
1. Intake	Junior fills a form: name, branch, batch, hometown, photo, "about me" text, socials, fun fact.	Google Form
2. Storage	Every response is saved as a structured row (with a public image URL) that both the website and the design tool can read.	Database (Sheet or Supabase)
3. Design fill	That row's text + photo is automatically dropped into your ready-made Canva grid template.	Canva Bulk Create / auto-fill
4. Publish	(a) Final grid images are ready to upload to Instagram. (b) The same data instantly appears as a searchable profile card on your website.	You (Instagram) + Website (auto)

The key insight: **the Google Form response IS the database entry IS the design input IS the website profile.** You only ask the junior to fill one form, once. Everything else reads from that same source of truth, so nobody on your team ever manually retypes a name or re-uploads a photo.

2. Step 1 — The Google Form

This is your only manual-entry touchpoint, so design it carefully once.

Recommended fields

- **Full Name** — short text
- **Preferred/Display Name** (what should show on the post) — short text
- **Branch / Department** — dropdown (CSE, ECE, ME, etc.) so it's clean data, not free text
- **Batch / Year** — dropdown (2025, 2026...)
- **Hometown / City** — short text
- **Photo upload** — Google Forms' native "File upload" question type (saves straight to a Drive folder)
- **About Me / Bio** — paragraph, with a strict character limit stated in the question (e.g. "280 characters max — it must fit the design") so text doesn't overflow your Canva template
- **Instagram handle** (optional) — short text, for a follow-back tag
- **Societies/clubs interested in** — checkboxes, doubles as data for your clubs page later
- **Consent checkbox** — "I agree my photo, name and bio can be posted on the college Instagram page and website." (Required — see Section 11.)

Tip: turn on *"Collect email addresses"* in Form settings. It lets you contact someone if their photo is low-resolution or their bio is too long, and it naturally prevents duplicate submissions.

Photo quality matters most for the grid look. Add a short line in the form itself: "Upload a clear, well-lit photo, portrait orientation, face clearly visible — low quality photos may be asked to be resubmitted." This alone will save you 80% of your manual cleanup work.

3. Step 2 — The Database

You need somewhere every response lands automatically, in a structured table, that both the design tool and the website can pull from. You have two realistic options given your skill level:

Option A — Google Sheets (fastest to start, zero setup)

Every Google Form auto-links to a Google Sheet. It already IS your database. Good enough for the design-automation step. Limitation: connecting a live website directly to a Sheet for real-time search works, but gets messy once you have 500+ entries and want fast search/filtering.

Option B — Supabase (recommended for the website)

Supabase is a free-tier backend (built on Postgres) that gives you a real database, file storage for photos, and an auto-generated API — with no backend code required. Every "vibe-coding" tool (Lovable, v0, Bolt, Antigravity) has native, drag-and-drop Supabase integration, so this is the standard pairing for exactly your situation.

Practical setup: use a small automation (Google Apps Script — a few lines, or a no-code tool like Zapier/Make/n8n free tier) that fires whenever a new Form response arrives, and copies it into your Supabase table + uploads the photo to Supabase Storage. This keeps Sheets and Supabase in sync automatically, so you get the best of both.

Suggested table structure

Column	Type	Notes
id	auto number	unique row id
name	text	
branch	text	for filter dropdown
batch_year	text	for filter dropdown
hometown	text	
bio	text	capped length
photo_url	text (URL)	public link to stored image
instagram_handle	text	optional
clubs_interested	text/array	optional, feeds clubs page
grid_batch_no	number	which set of 9 this person belongs to — see Section 4
post_status	text	"pending / designed / posted" — lets you track progress

4. Step 3 — Auto-generating the Canva Grid Posts

This is the part you most want automated, and the good news is Canva already has a built-in feature that does almost exactly this — no custom code needed.

Method A — Canva Bulk Create (recommended, easiest)

Canva's **Bulk Create** tool takes your existing template, and a spreadsheet (or connected data source), and auto-fills a new copy of the design for every row — mapping each column to a text box or image placeholder you mark in the template. This is literally built for "paste text and photo into a fixed design, repeatedly."

1. In Canva, open your 9-grid template and mark which text box = "Name", which = "Bio", which image frame = "Photo" (Canva calls this tagging data fields).
2. Export your Google Sheet (or Supabase table) as a CSV with matching column headers.
3. Run Bulk Create → it generates one design per row, fully filled in, in seconds.
4. Since you have two grid layouts and "9 posts = 1 finished picture," batch people into groups of 9 (your *grid_batch_no* column from Section 3), run Bulk Create once per batch of 9, then export all 9 tiles.

Canva Bulk Create is available on Canva Pro (many colleges/student orgs can get Canva Pro free via Canva for Education/Nonprofits — worth checking if your society isn't on it already).

Method B — Script it yourself (more control, more setup)

If you outgrow Canva's limits, an AI coding tool (Gemini, Antigravity, etc.) can write you a small Python script using the Pillow (PIL) library that: opens your template as a base PNG, pastes the student's photo into the correct frame (auto-cropped to fit), writes their name/bio in the correct font/position, and exports the final tile. This gives you pixel-perfect control and can run on hundreds of entries in one go — but it needs someone to set up the coordinates once per template. Good "Phase 2" upgrade once the manual version proves the idea works.

The "interconnected grid" (panoramic 9-grid) mechanic

For readers who haven't done this before: a 9-grid Instagram "panorama" is one large image split into 9 equal squares, uploaded as 9 separate posts in reverse order (last tile first) so that when viewed on a profile grid (3 columns × 3 rows) they reassemble into one connected picture. Since your two Canva designs are the finished big pictures, the slicing into 9 tiles can also be done with Canva's own "Split into grid" / "Instagram grid maker" templates, or dedicated free tools (many exist as web tools — search "Instagram grid maker" — and some Canva apps in the app store do it directly), or the same Pillow script can slice and export the 9 tiles automatically as the very last step.

5. Step 4 — The Website

This is where your "searchable directory of the college" vision comes together. Structure it as a small multi-page site, not just one long page.

Core pages

- **Home** — hero banner, "Meet the Juniors of [Year]", quick search bar, featured/recent profiles
- **Directory / Search** — grid of profile cards (photo + name + branch), with filters: branch, batch year, hometown; search bar by name
- **Individual Profile Page** — full bio, photo, Instagram link, "share this profile" button (great for the junior themselves to share once they're posted)
- **Societies & Clubs** — directory of every club with logo, one-line description, link to their own Instagram/socials, and the join/contact link
- **Campus Map** — an image map or embedded interactive map with labelled buildings/blocks
- **Faculty / Departments** — optional directory of HODs/faculty per branch
- **About Parichay** — what this initiative is, who runs it, credits

How search should work

Since your data already lives in Supabase (a real database), search and filtering is a standard, well-solved feature — this is one of the easiest parts for an AI page-builder to generate correctly, because "searchable directory with filters connected to a database" is an extremely common pattern it has seen many times.

What to literally type into your AI builder (Lovable / v0 / Bolt)

These tools work best with a clear, specific brief. A good starting prompt looks like:

"Build a college student directory website called Parichay. Connect it to my Supabase project [give project URL/keys]. Table 'students' has columns: name, branch, batch_year, hometown, bio, photo_url, instagram_handle. Build: (1) a home page with a hero section and search bar, (2) a directory page showing student cards in a responsive grid with filters for branch and batch_year and a live search-by-name box, (3) an individual profile page at /student/[id], (4) a clubs page pulling from a 'clubs' table, (5) a campus map page. Use a clean, modern college-website aesthetic, mobile-first."

You can paste this brief as-is (swap in your real details) into Lovable, v0, or Bolt to get a working first draft, then iterate in plain English ("make the cards bigger", "add a dark mode toggle", "sort by most recent").

6. Step 5 — Posting Automation: What's Realistic

Fully automatic, code-free posting straight to Instagram is the hardest 20% of this project — worth knowing upfront so you don't get stuck chasing it before the rest works.

Approach	Effort	Notes
Manual upload	Low	Realistic for v1: Bulk Create exports 9 ready tiles, you upload them yourself in ~2 minutes per set. Good starting point.
Scheduler tools (Later, Buffer, Meta Business Suite)	Low-Medium	Free tiers let you queue posts in advance with correct ordering — still needs the images pre-made, but removes the "remembering to post" burden.

Meta Graph API (Instagram Content Publishing API)	High	True programmatic auto-posting. Requires a Facebook Developer app, an Instagram <i>Business</i> account linked to a Facebook Page, and app review for certain permissions. Doable with AI coding help, but it's a real integration project on its own — treat as a "Phase 3" stretch goal, not a v1 requirement.
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Recommendation: launch with manual/scheduler-based posting first. Prove the automation of *design generation* (the actually tedious part) and the website work well, then only invest in the Graph API if the team still wants full hands-off posting later.

7. Recommended Tool Stack

Mapped to tools you mentioned already having access to:

Layer	Tool	Why
Data intake	Google Forms	Free, familiar to juniors, native file upload for photos
Raw storage	Google Sheets	Auto-linked to the Form, zero setup
Real database + image storage	Supabase	Free tier, gives you a real searchable database + photo storage + auto API, integrates natively with AI builders
Sync Sheets → Supabase	Google Apps Script or n8n/Make (free tier)	Small automation, can be "vibe-coded" with Gemini's help
Design automation	Canva Bulk Create	Auto-fills your existing 2 templates with text + photo
Website frontend	Lovable / v0 / Bolt ("Snitch")	AI-generated frontend, connect directly to Supabase, no manual coding
Hosting	Vercel	Free tier, one-click deploy from these AI builders
Posting (v1)	Manual / Later / Buffer free tier	Simple scheduling, no API approval needed
Posting (later, optional)	Meta Graph API	True automation, higher effort — Phase 3

8. Build Roadmap

Phase 0 — Setup (Week 1)

- Finalize form fields + character limits for bio
- Create Supabase project, define the students/clubs tables
- Mark data-field placeholders inside your 2 Canva templates

Phase 1 — Pipeline test (Week 2)

- Collect ~10 test responses (yourselves/friends)
- Run Bulk Create on that batch of 9-10, confirm the grid looks right when sliced
- Manually post the test grid to a private/test Instagram account to check spacing/order

Phase 2 — Website v1 (Weeks 3-4)

- Brief Lovable/v0/Bolt with the prompt template from Section 5
- Connect it to Supabase, get Home + Directory + Profile pages working
- Deploy to Vercel, test search/filter on real data

Phase 3 — Public launch (Week 5+)

- Open the real Google Form to all juniors
- Process real batches of 9 as they come in, publish to Instagram + confirm website updates live
- Add Clubs/Map/Faculty pages once the core loop is running smoothly

Phase 4 — Optional upgrades

- Custom Pillow/PIL script to replace Canva Bulk Create for full design control
- Meta Graph API for true auto-posting
- Admin dashboard to approve/edit a bio before it goes live

9. Team Roles

Role	Responsibility
Data/Form owner	Owns the Google Form, monitors responses, flags bad photos/over-length bios
Design operator	Runs Canva Bulk Create per batch of 9, checks output quality before posting
Website builder	Owns the Lovable/v0/Bolt project, iterates on prompts, manages Supabase
Posting/social lead	Uploads final grid to Instagram in correct order, manages captions/tags
Consent/privacy lead	Confirms every entry has consent ticked before it's designed or posted

A team of 3-4 people can run this comfortably once the pipeline is set up — most of the ongoing work becomes "press the Bulk Create button" and "upload 9 images," not manual design work.

10. Extra Feature Ideas

- **"Random Junior" button** on the site — fun way to encourage exploration of the directory
- **Batch/branch leaderboard** — "most viewed profile this week" (light gamification)
- **QR code per profile** — printable QR linking straight to a student's page, useful for orientation-day booths or ID card inserts
- **"Find your senior" feature** — a parallel directory or filter so seniors from the same hometown/branch can be found too
- **Downloadable campus map PDF** alongside the interactive map
- **Society/club application forms** embedded directly on each club's page
- **Admin approval queue** — nothing goes live/posted until one person on your team taps "approve," preventing typos or inappropriate submissions from going out
- **Dark/light theme toggle**, since most AI builders support this with one prompt
- **End-of-year "class of ____" archive** — old batches stay searchable in the directory even after their grid is fully posted, turning the site into a growing alumni-style archive
- **Auto-generated Instagram caption drafts** — have the AI tool draft a caption per batch of 9 using the bios, which your social lead can edit before posting

11. Risks, Consent & Data-Handling Notes

- **Explicit consent is essential** — you're collecting and publishing photos + personal text about minors-adjacent/young adult students. Keep the consent checkbox mandatory, and state clearly in the form what will be public (Instagram + website) versus private.
- **Data you don't need, don't collect** — phone numbers, addresses etc. aren't needed for this use case; stick to what the directory actually displays.
- **Right to be removed** — have a simple way (an email/contact form) for someone to request their profile be taken down later.
- **Storage/API limits** — free tiers (Supabase, Vercel) are generous but not infinite; keep photo file sizes reasonable (compress on upload) so you don't hit storage caps as the directory grows year over year.
- **Get institutional sign-off** — since this represents the college publicly, loop in your faculty advisor / student affairs office early, especially before the site goes live college-wide.

12. Cost Summary

Tool	Free tier sufficient for this project?
Google Forms + Sheets	Yes, fully free, no limits that matter here
Supabase	Yes — free tier covers database + storage for a project this size comfortably
Vercel	Yes — free tier is standard for hosting sites like this
Canva	Bulk Create needs Canva Pro — check Canva for Education/Nonprofits for free access
Lovable / v0 / Bolt	Free tiers exist with usage limits; fine for building + iterating
Meta Graph API (if pursued later)	Free, but requires developer app setup/approval

Bottom line: this entire project is realistically buildable at **■0** in tooling cost, using free tiers across the board — the only real "cost" is team time setting up the pipeline once.